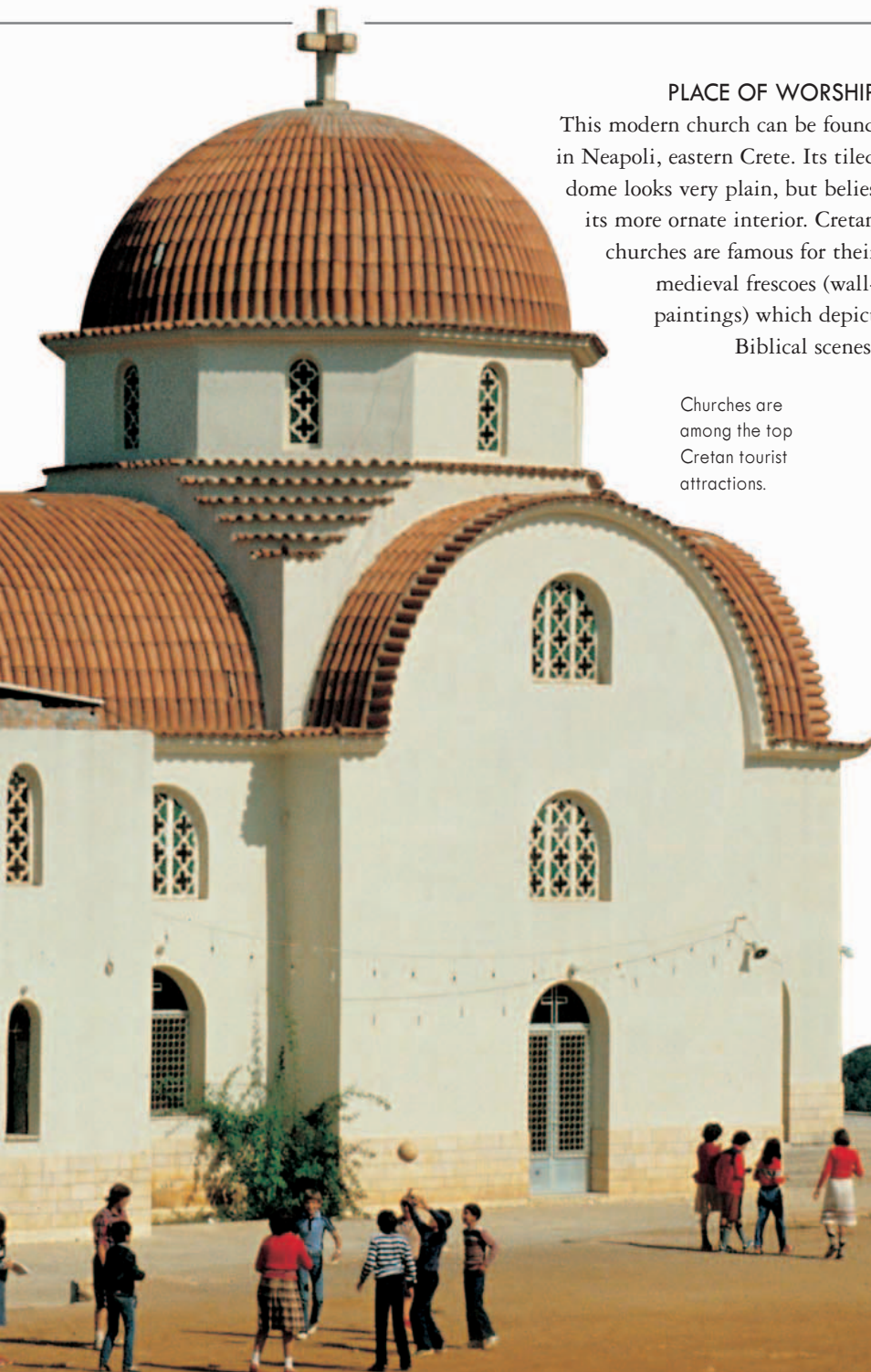




for cultivating olives, grapes, and other fruit. Cretan olive trees represent more than 30 percent of the Greek crop. Farmers keep flocks of sheep and goats for their milk, wool, and meat. From 1699 to 1898 Crete was under the

control of the Ottoman Empire but prior to that it was ruled by the Venetians. The Greek spoken on the island differs slightly from that of the mainland and retains traces of these conquests.



PLACE OF WORSHIP

This modern church can be found in Neapoli, eastern Crete. Its tiled dome looks very plain, but belies its more ornate interior. Cretan churches are famous for their medieval frescoes (wall-paintings) which depict Biblical scenes.

Churches are among the top Cretan tourist attractions.



COFFEE AND COMPANIONSHIP

The local *kafenion* is the center of village life in rural Crete. Men, particularly, spend hours drinking coffee or *raki*, snacking, gossiping, discussing politics, and playing *tavli* (backgammon) at the local coffee-house.



THE LOCAL BREW

Cretan *tsikoudia* or *raki* is an alcoholic drink made from the residue left after grapes have been crushed to make wine. The traditional time for making the drink is October.



ISLAND FOOD

Because Crete is an island, seafood features largely on its menu, with octopus a common appetizer. Fish, beef, and rabbit are also staple foods, and salads are served at every meal.